

SETTING

Where and when a story takes place



1 What is it?

Setting

Setting is the **time and place** a story happens in — and a skilled writer uses it to do far more than just tell the reader where they are.

place + time = setting

2 See it in action

Setting a scene

The abandoned fairground stood silent under a bruised evening sky.

Reflecting mood

The office was grey, fluorescent, and airless — nowhere anyone would choose to be.

A contrasting setting

After the chaos of the city, the quiet cottage felt like another world.

Time as setting

It was three in the morning, the hour when nothing good ever happens.



Good spot!

When you read a setting description, ask: **what mood does this place create**, and why did the writer choose it over anywhere else?

FUN FACT

The setting of a story is sometimes called "the silent character" — because although it never speaks, a carefully chosen setting shapes how a reader feels about everything that happens in it.

3 Why writers use it

Setting helps writers: establish atmosphere before anything happens, ground the reader in a believable world, and use physical place to reflect a character's emotional state or a story's central theme.

Setting is rarely neutral — a writer chooses a specific place and time because of what it suggests, not just because the story has to happen somewhere.

4 Where you'll spot it

Gothic & horror fiction

An isolated, crumbling setting (an old house, a fog-bound moor) builds dread before any events occur.

Coming-of-age stories

A familiar childhood setting revisited as an adult is a classic way to show how much a character has changed.



Watch out!

Don't just describe a setting for its own sake — always ask what MOOD or THEME it's creating. A setting description that does no extra work is a missed opportunity.



Keep going!

Look for a setting that **contrasts** with what's happening in the plot (a cheerful setting during a sad scene, say) — that contrast is often deliberate and worth naming.

5 Quick recap

The time and place of a story

Can create mood or atmosphere

Often reflects character or theme



Mfalme says...

Try describing the same room twice — once to feel welcoming, once to feel threatening — using only the details you choose to include or leave out.